Linguistic and cultural commonality prevailed in the *janapadas*, whereas in the *mahajanapadas*, different social and cultural groups lived. With the emergence of kingdoms, the struggle for supremacy among different states occurred frequently. Sacrifices such as Rajasuya and Asvamedha were performed to signify the imperial sway of monarchs over their rivals. The Rig Vedic title of 'Rajan' was replaced by impressive titles such as Samrat, Ekrat, Virat or Bhoja.

Northern India extended from the Kabul Valley in the north to the Godavari in the South. It witnessed the rise of sixteen states known as *Mahajanapadas* or sixteen great states: Kasi, Kosla, Anga, Magadha, Vajji, Malla, Chedi, Vatsa, Kuru, Panchala, Matsya, Surasena, Assaka, Avanti, Gandhara and Kamboja.

Growth of Royal Power

The king enjoyed absolute power. The *sabha* of the Rig Vedic period ceased to exist. The king sought the aid and support of the *samiti* on matters like war, peace and fiscal policies. However, in spite of the existence of the assemblies, the power of the king kept increasing. The *Satapatha Brahmana* describes the king as infallible and immune from all punishments. The growth of royal power was reflected in the enlarged administrative structure. The king was now assisted by a group of officers such as *Bhugadugha* (collector of taxes), *Suta* (charioteer), the *Aksharapa* (superintendent of gambling), *Kshattri* (chamberlin), *Gorikartana* (king's companion in the chase), *Palogola* (courtier), *Takshan* (carpenter) and *Rathakara* (chariotmaker). In addition, there were the ecclesiastical and military officials like the *Purohita* (chaplain), the *Senani* (army general) and the *Gramani* (leader of the village).In the later Vedic period, Gramani, who acted both a civil and military officer, was the link through which the royal authority was enforced in the village. The king administered justice and occasionally delegated his judicial power to *Adhyakshas* (royal officials). In the villages, *Gramyavadin* (village judge) and *Sabha* (court) decided the cases. Punishments for crimes were severe.

The Rise of Magadha Kingdom

The polity followed in kingdoms was different from that of gana-sanghas. Kingdoms operated with a centralised government. Political power was concentrated in the ruling family, which had become a dynasty, with succession becoming hereditary. There were advisory bodies such as *parishad* (ministers) and *sabha* (advisory council). The *sabha* collected the revenue and remitted it to the treasury in the capital of the kingdom, from where it was redistributed for the public expenses, such as maintenance of army and salaries to state officials.

Of the kingdoms mentioned in the literature of the period, Kashi, Kosala and Magadha are considered to be powerful. The only republic that rivalled these kingdoms was the Vrijjis, whose capital was Vaisali. In the struggle for control for the Gangetic Plain, which had strategic and economic advantages, the Magadha kingdom emerged victorious. Bimbisara was the first important king of Magadha. Through matrimonial alliances with the high-status Lichchavi clan of Vaishali and the ruling family in Kosala, Bimbisara went on to conquer Anga (in West Bengal now), thereby gaining access to the Ganges delta.

Bimbisara succeeded in establishing a comprehensive structure of administration. Village was the basic unit of his administrative system. Apart from villages (*gramas*), there were fields and pastures as well as wasteland and the forests (*aranya*, *khetra* and *vana*). Each village was brought under a *gramani* (headman), who was responsible for collecting taxes and remitting them to the state treasury. Officers appointed to measure the land under cultivation and assess the value of crop were to assist the *gramani* in his task. Land tax (*bali*) was the main source of revenue to the kingdom and the share of the produce (*bhaga*) was determined

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